A Note on These Texts

- **What is dogma.** That there is a Purgatory; that the souls there are helped by the suffrages of the faithful; that an indulgence remits temporal punishment; and that an indulgence may be offered for the dead by way of suffrage — all this is defined doctrine (Trent, Session XXV; CCC 1030–1032, 1471–1479).
- **What is discipline.** The November grants, the eight-day window, and the conditions are a concession of the Apostolic Penitentiary and can be altered. They bind no one under pain of sin, and the Church warns against treating the visits as an obligation whose omission invites misfortune.
- **What is popular piety.** The cemetery visit, the parish list of the dead, the nine days, and the thirty Masses are customs the Church commends, not laws she imposes; she praises them while insisting that they rest on the communion of saints and not on fear (Directory on Popular Piety, § 260).
- **No days and years.** Since Pope St. Paul VI's *Indulgentiarum Doctrina* (1967) the Church no longer reckons indulgences in days or years, and no grant promises that a soul is released on a given date.
- **The texts.** The Latin of the All Saints Collect and of *Fidelium Deus* is from the typical editions; the English of the All Saints Collect is the approved translation. The psalm and the *Libera me* are given in the traditional English of the Roman Rite. The prayer for the saints' intercession, the prayer for the holy souls, and the prayer for those who mourn are devotional compositions, and are marked as such.
- **Wording varies.** Approved English translations of the Missal differ by territory, and the rendering of the psalms differs between psalters; none of the vernacular texts here is normative except where noted.
- **Reading these pages aloud.** The bold lead-ins are editorial notes and are not part of any prayer; the indented blocks are the texts themselves, to be read one line at a time, by one voice or by many.
- **The fuller studies.** For the doctrine, the ritual, and the sources, see Prayers for the Dying and the Dead, The November Plenary Indulgences for the Holy Souls, Purgatory, and the Novena for the Poor Souls in Purgatory.

All Saints and All Souls

A Pamphlet of Prayers and Practices for the First Eight Days of November

1. The Two Days

The first two days of November are one act of faith about the communion of saints: **1 November** honours all who are with Christ in glory, **2 November** prays for all still being made ready for it.

All Saints, 1 November. A solemnity, and in the Latin Church a holy day of obligation, honouring every saint in heaven, canonized or not: "of all nations and tribes and peoples and tongues, standing before the throne and in sight of the Lamb" (Apoc. 7:9).

All Souls, 2 November. The Commemoration of All the Faithful Departed, not a holy day of obligation. The Church prays for all who died in God's grace but are not yet perfectly purified, that God would remit what still binds them and bring them to the vision of his face — the doctrine of Purgatory (CCC 1030–1032), professed at Lyons II, Florence, and Trent.

One communion. Death does not sever the members of Christ; it changes how they help one another (CCC 946–962). November is the Church's exercise of that charity.

2. All Saints' Day

The Collect of the feast, in the Latin typical edition and in the approved English.

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Omnipotens sempiterne Deus,
qui nos omnium Sanctorum tuorum merita
sub una tribuisti celebritate venerari,
quaesumus, ut optata nobis tuae propitiationis abundantia,
multiplicatis intercessoribus, largiaris.
Per Dominum nostrum Iesum Christum, Filium tuum,
qui tecum vivit et regnat in unitate Spiritus Sancti, Deus,
per omnia saecula saeculorum. Amen.

Almighty ever-living God,
by whose gift we venerate in one celebration
the merits of all the Saints,
bestow on us, we pray,
through the prayers of so many intercessors,
an abundance of the reconciliation with you
for which we earnestly long.
Through our Lord Jesus Christ, your Son,
who lives and reigns with you in the unity of the Holy Spirit,
one God, for ever and ever. Amen.
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A prayer asking the intercession of all the saints — a devotional composition.

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All you saints of God, who see him face to face,
remember us who still walk by faith,
and lead our departed brothers and sisters into the light.
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7. Praying for the Dead All Year

Have Mass offered. This is the first thing to do, and the only thing the Church calls pre-eminent. A priest may apply the Mass for anyone, living or dead (canon 901); ask the parish office for a Mass intention for the repose of the soul you name.

The offering. The customary offering given with a Mass intention — the stipend — is a contribution toward the priest's support, not a price for grace (canons 945–952). Where a family cannot afford one, the Mass is still offered; no one is to be deprived of the suffrage of the altar for want of money.

The Gregorian Thirty. An old custom: thirty Masses on thirty consecutive days for one soul, associated with the *Dialogues* of St. Gregory the Great. It is a pious practice, not a Church law. It adds nothing to what a single Mass already obtains for the dead; what it adds is persistence.

The novena. For nine days — the nine days the apostles spent with Our Lady between the Ascension and Pentecost — pray in one place and at one hour if you can: the Sign of the Cross, the *Requiem aeternam*, the *De Profundis*, a decade of the Rosary, a short reading (John 14:1–6; Romans 8:31–39; 1 Corinthians 15:51–57), your own prayer for the dead by name, and the *Requiem aeternam* again.

Keep the days and the anniversary. Many Catholic families keep the third, seventh, thirtieth, and fortieth day, and then the anniversary each year. These are pious customs, not requirements, and they set no limit on how long prayers or Masses may be offered; a Mass may be requested years afterwards.

Give alms. Prayer, fasting, and almsgiving are the Church's ordinary penance, and they may be offered for the dead as for the living. A gift to the poor, a work of mercy, or a sacrifice made in the name of the dead unites the whole Church's charity to the suffrage.

Pray for the forgotten. Some died with no one to pray for them. A single *Requiem aeternam* for "all the faithful departed, especially those most in need of thy mercy" covers them all.

The November lists. Many parishes keep a book or list of the dead through November. Ask for a name to be inscribed, and pray for the other names you find there; a name written down is a promise of prayer kept by others when we ourselves forget.

In the East. The Eastern Catholic Churches hold the same doctrine of Purgatory and of suffrage for the dead, though the indulgence as a canonical institution is Western. Their own forms are the Divine Liturgy offered for the departed, the **Panikhida**, the third-, ninth- and fortieth-day memorials, the **Soul Saturdays**, and the cry **"Memory eternal"** (*Vechnaya Pamyat*). A Latin Catholic may share in them without scruple.

6. The Church's Farewell

The *Libera me*, from the Office of the Dead.

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Deliver me, O Lord, from eternal death
in that awful day,
when the heavens and the earth shall be moved,
when thou shalt come to judge the world by fire.
Trembling and awe-struck am I, and I fear exceedingly,
while I await the coming wrath and the day of judgment.
That day, the day of wrath, of calamity and misery,
the great and bitter day.
Eternal rest grant unto them, O Lord,
and let perpetual light shine upon them.
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The *In Paradisum*, sung as the body is carried from the church.

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May angels lead you into paradise;
may the martyrs receive you at your coming
and lead you to the holy city of Jerusalem.
May a choir of angels receive you,
and with Lazarus, who once was poor,
may you have eternal rest.
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The commendation, the Church's prayer at the funeral, usable at a vigil, a graveside, or an anniversary.

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Remember, O Lord, your servant N.,
who has gone before us with the sign of faith
and rests in the sleep of peace.
Grant N., we beseech you, a place of refreshment, light, and peace,
that N. may pass from death to that life which never ends,
through Christ our Lord. Amen.
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At home. The Rosary may be said for the dead without any special form; state the intention before you begin, and the Glorious Mysteries are especially fitting. At a wake, the Rosary, the *De Profundis*, and the *Requiem aeternam* make a complete vigil.

A prayer for those who mourn — a devotional composition, for the family and friends of the dead.

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Lord God, who wept at the grave of Lazarus,
look on those who grieve today.
You know the empty house, the name no longer spoken.
Be their portion and their peace;
give them sleep at night and courage by day,
and keep them in the hope of the resurrection,
where every tear is wiped away.
Through Christ our Lord. Amen.
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3. All Souls' Day

The reading — the Church's oldest words of consolation over the grave.

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But the souls of the just are in the hand of God,
and the torment of death shall not touch them.
In the sight of the unwise they seemed to die:
and their departure was taken for misery:
and their going away from us, for utter destruction:
but they are in peace. (Wis. 3:1–3)
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The Church's prayer for all the faithful departed, from the funeral rites.

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Fidelium, Deus, omnium Conditor et Redemptor,
animabus famulorum famularumque tuarum
remissionem cunctorum tribue peccatorum;
ut indulgentiam, quam semper optaverunt,
piis supplicationibus consequantur.
Qui vivis et regnas in saecula saeculorum. Amen.

O God, the Creator and Redeemer of all the faithful,
grant to the souls of your servants departed
the remission of all their sins,
that through our pious supplications
they may obtain the pardon which they have always desired.
You live and reign for ever and ever. Amen.
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A prayer for the holy souls — a devotional composition, to be said before the Blessed Sacrament or at a graveside.

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Lord Jesus Christ, you descended into the depths
and preached to the spirits in prison:
look with pity on the souls who wait for you,
who love you and cannot yet see you.
Wash away what still clings to them,
complete in them the work of your Passion,
and bring them quickly to the joy of your face,
where with the Father and the Holy Spirit
you live and reign for ever and ever. Amen.
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Why the Church prays for the dead. The practice is older than its definition. Judas Maccabeus sent money to Jerusalem for a sacrifice to be offered for the dead, "thinking well and religiously concerning the resurrection" (2 Macc. 12:43–46), and the oldest Christian inscriptions ask for prayer for the departed. At Trent the Church defined what the practice presupposes: that the souls in Purgatory are helped by the suffrages of the faithful, and principally by the sacrifice of the altar (DH 1820). The practice is therefore no sentiment but an act of faith — in the communion of saints, and in the power of the Cross applied beyond death.

4. The Plenary Indulgence of 1–8 November

What an indulgence is. It is not a pardon for sin, and it does not forgive guilt. It is the remission, before God, of the temporal punishment still owed for sins whose guilt has already been forgiven in Confession (CCC 1471). Because the Church is one communion, she may offer the treasury of Christ's satisfactions and of his saints, and she does so by the power of the keys — for the living by jurisdiction, for the dead by way of suffrage (*per modum suffragii*).

The Apostolic Penitentiary attaches five grants to these days — two plenary and three partial — and all five are applicable **only to the souls in Purgatory** (*Enchiridion Indulgentiarum*, Concessio 29).

Plenary — the cemetery, each day. Visit a cemetery devoutly on any day from 1 to 8 November and pray for the dead, even only mentally. No formula and no minimum length of stay is required.

Plenary — the church, 2 November. On All Souls' Day, visit a church or oratory and there recite the Our Father and the Creed, Apostles' or Nicene. With the consent of the Ordinary this visit may be transferred to All Saints' Day or to the adjacent Sunday.

Partial — all year. A devout cemetery visit with prayer for the dead; Lauds or Vespers of the Office of the Dead; or the invocation *Requiem aeternam dona eis, Domine*. These three carry a partial indulgence on any day of the year, not only in November.

The conditions. For a plenary indulgence there is required the indulgenced work, sacramental Confession, Holy Communion, prayer for the intentions of the Holy Father — one Our Father and one Hail Mary fully satisfies this — and the exclusion of all attachment to sin, even venial sin. These may be fulfilled several days before or after the work, though it is fitting to receive Communion and pray for the Pope on the day itself. One Confession serves for several plenary indulgences; Communion and the papal prayer must be repeated for each. If the full conditions are not met, the indulgence is partial (Normae 6–11).

Four things worth knowing.

- These two plenary grants **cannot be applied to yourself**. They are for the dead alone. For a plenary of your own, use the ordinary works: adoration, the Rosary, the Stations of the Cross, the reading of Scripture.
- **Only one plenary indulgence may be gained each day.** On 2 November, choose deliberately between the church visit and the cemetery.
- The Church **entreats, she does not command**. The measure of the effect in any soul rests with God, which is why the Church says "may they rest in peace", never "they are now released".
- **The Mass remains the chief suffrage.** "The souls there detained are helped by the suffrages of the faithful, but principally by the acceptable sacrifice of the altar" (Trent, Session XXV; DH 1820).

5. At the Grave

A simple order for a cemetery visit. Go to the grave, or to any cemetery plot. Begin with the Sign of the Cross. Name before God the dead you carry, and pray for them in silence — a spoken formula is not required. Pray the *Requiem aeternam*. Add the *De Profundis*. End with the Sign of the Cross. If holy water is at hand, bless yourself and the grave, and stay a moment in silence before you go. There is no rite the Church requires of a private visit, and no obligation to make one; the visit flows from the bond between the living and the dead, and not from any fear of omitting it.

The *Requiem aeternam*, the Church's shortest and most repeated prayer for the dead.

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Requiem aeternam dona eis, Domine,
et lux perpetua luceat eis.
Requiescant in pace. Amen.

Eternal rest grant unto them, O Lord,
and let perpetual light shine upon them.
May they rest in peace. Amen.
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The *De Profundis*, Psalm 129 — the psalm of the Church's mourning, prayed for the dead since the first centuries.

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Out of the depths I have cried to thee, O Lord:
Lord, hear my voice.
Let thy ears be attentive to the voice of my supplication.
If thou, O Lord, wilt mark iniquities: Lord, who shall stand it?
For with thee there is merciful forgiveness:
and by reason of thy law, I have waited for thee, O Lord.
My soul hath relied on his word:
my soul hath hoped in the Lord.
From the morning watch even until night,
let Israel hope in the Lord.
Because with the Lord there is mercy:
and with him plentiful redemption.
And he shall redeem Israel from all his iniquities.
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The Office of the Dead. Lauds or Vespers from the Church's Office for the dead, prayed alone or with a family at a wake, carries a partial indulgence on any day. It is the Church's own hour of prayer, not a private devotion; the psalms may be read by one person or by several in turn, with the appointed reading and the *Requiem aeternam* to close. Where a parish prays the Office publicly in November, join it.

Crosses, holy water, and cremation. A cross or the *R.I.P.* cut into a stone is a profession of faith, not decoration. Cremation is permitted, provided it is not chosen as a denial of the resurrection of the body, and the ashes are to be laid in a cemetery or other sacred place — not scattered, divided, or kept in a home.